LISTEN · LEARN · SPEAK

Why We Put Things Off (And How to Stop)

Why procrastination is about feelings, not laziness, why your brain treats "future you" like a stranger, the two-minute trick, natural English for plans, delays and deadlines – and Lucy's passport form.



Name: _____

Date: _____

My score: _____ / 100 ⭐

★ How to use this worksheet

1 · Before you listen 🧠
Do the warm-up and learn the key words. Questions with 🧠 can be answered before listening.

2 · While you listen 🎧
Answer the 🎧 questions. The ⏱ times show where to find each part of the video.

3 · Don't put it off! ⏱
Jack's tip: open this worksheet today – even if you only do the first exercise!

0 Warm-up: My procrastination check

fun · no points

Be honest! Tick everything that is true for you. 😅

- ☐ 🧹 I clean when I should work
- ☐ 🗓️ I say "I'll start tomorrow"
- ☐ ⏰ I do things at the last minute
- ☐ 📧 I leave emails for days
- ☐ 📱 My phone is my easy escape
- ☐ ✅ I usually start straight away

My procrastination score: _____ / 6

Guess! Lucy avoided her passport form for three weeks. When she finally did it, how long did it take?

(a) eleven minutes (b) two hours (c) a whole weekend

🎧 **Check your guess at ⏱ 22:00**

Jack: "My bike's been broken for two months. Future Jack will fix it!" 🚲



💬 Let's talk

Say your answers out loud – or write them in your notebook.

1. What's one thing you've been putting off?

2. What do you do instead – your "spice jars"?

3. Do you work better with a deadline? Why?

4. What would "future you" say to you today?

1 Key words

vocabulary · 10 points

Match each word or phrase (1–10) to its meaning (a–j). Write the letter in the box. 🧠 Then check at ⏱️ 14:33 and ⏱️ 15:52

- ☐ **1.** to procrastinate
- ☐ **2.** to put something off
- ☐ **3.** to get round to
- ☐ **4.** a deadline
- ☐ **5.** at the last minute
- ☐ **6.** momentum
- ☐ **7.** chronic
- ☐ **8.** overwhelmed
- ☐ **9.** to revise (for an exam)
- ☐ **10.** to forgive yourself

a) to delay something to a later time
b) the force that keeps something moving once it has started
c) to delay doing something you should do, usually because you don't want to
d) to study again to prepare for an exam (British English)
e) the time or day by which you have to finish something
f) to stop being angry with yourself for a mistake
g) to finally do something, after a long time of not doing it
h) happening again and again, for a long time
i) at the latest possible time
j) feeling that something is too big or difficult to deal with



Pronunciation corner 🔊 pro-**CRAS**-ti-nate · pro-cras-ti-**NA**-tion · mo-**MEN**-tum · **DEAD**-line · o-ver-**WHELMED**. Say it: *"I keep putting it off – let's just get it over with!"*

2 First listen: the big idea

listening · 2 points

Watch the whole episode once without stopping. Which sentence is the **main message**? 🎧

- (a) People put things off because they are lazy, so they need a better calendar.
- (b) The best way to stop procrastinating is to be very hard on yourself.
- (c) We put things off to escape a bad feeling – tiny first steps and being kind to yourself (and "future you") help.



Jack's tip: First listen = the **big picture**. Don't stop the video and don't worry about every word. Second listen = the **details**. That's when you answer the 🎧 questions.

🔮 **Predict before you listen!** (no points) Seven of these words are in the episode. One is **not**. Circle the one you think you **won't** hear – then check while you listen.

kettle · spice jars · curtains · fridge · biscuits · bike · umbrella · dentist

3 Know it or hear it? quiz + listening 10 points

Circle a, b or c. Questions 🧠 1–5: you can probably answer them **before** you listen. Questions 🎧 6–10: listen to find the answer.



🧠 YOU MIGHT ALREADY KNOW

1. "I keep _____ it off."

(a) put
(b) to put
(c) putting

🧠 Grammar you know

2. "I finished my essay _____ the last minute."

(a) at
(b) in
(c) on

🧠 Tricky – think about it!

3. Which sentence is correct?

(a) I put off it.
(b) I put it off.
(c) I it put off.

🧠 Tricky – think about it!

4. "I finally bit the bullet." I…

(a) ate something very hard
(b) did something difficult I'd been avoiding
(c) got very angry

🧠 Imagine it!

5. "I'll do it _____." (= at a later time)

(a) after
(b) last
(c) later

🧠 Everyday English

🎉 **How many did you know?**
Now press play and test your ears!

🎧 LISTEN AND FIND OUT

6. How long did Lucy avoid the passport form?

(a) three days
(b) three weeks
(c) three months

🎧 ⏱ 0:05

7. What did Lucy put in alphabetical order?

(a) her books
(b) her socks
(c) her spice jars

🎧 ⏱ 0:05

8. About how many adults are chronic procrastinators?

(a) 15–20%
(b) 1–2%
(c) 50–60%

🎧 ⏱ 2:57

9. In the brain scanner, thinking about "you in ten years" looked a lot like thinking about…

(a) your best friend
(b) a stranger
(c) your parents

🎧 ⏱ 5:54

10. What has Jack been putting off for two months?

(a) calling his mum
(b) cleaning the fridge
(c) fixing the wheel on his bike

🎧 ⏱ 9:37

🧂 **Fun fact:** Lucy's spice jars went from *allspice* to *turmeric* – and they're still in alphabetical order!

4 True or false? listening 6 points

Listen and circle **T** (true) or **F** (false). The ⏱️ times help you find the answer.

1	Lucy had promised to visit her grandmother in the spring.	T	F	⏱️ 0:05
2	Tim Pychyl says procrastination is mainly a time management problem.	T	F	⏱️ 3:40
3	Avoiding a task makes us feel better for a long time.	T	F	⏱️ 3:40
4	People who saw an older version of their face saved more money.	T	F	⏱️ 5:54
5	Students who forgave themselves procrastinated more before the second exam.	T	F	⏱️ 7:49
6	The self-forgiveness study was a survey, so it shows a link, not definite proof.	T	F	⏱️ 7:49

5 Three procrastination studies 🔍 listening 6 points



Which study is each sentence about? Write **A**, **B** or **C**. ⏱️ 2:57 · 5:54 · 7:49

A · How common? 📊
2007 · Piers Steel, University of Calgary

B · Future you 🧑
2009 · Hal Hershfield and colleagues, Stanford

C · Forgive yourself 💜
2010 · Wohl, Pychyl & Bennett, Carleton University

1	People lay in a brain scanner and thought about different people.	☐
2	It looked at hundreds of studies on procrastination.	☐
3	First-year students had two big exams during the term.	☐
4	About one in five adults put things off again and again.	☐
5	"You in ten years" looked more like a famous actor you've never met.	☐
6	Being kind to yourself after a mistake made it easier to start again.	☐

6 The procrastination circle new! complete the diagram 6 points



Write one word in each gap: **avoid · better · emotion · guilty · time · worse**. ⏱️ 3:40

😟 A task makes you feel bad: bored, worried or unsure. →

🏃 So you _____ it. (1) →

😌 You feel _____ – but only for a few minutes. (2) →

⏳ Now there's less time, and you feel _____. (3) →

😩 The task feels even _____! (4)

↻ … and the circle starts again

💬 Pychyl: "Procrastination is an _____ regulation problem, not a _____ management problem." (5, 6)



Lucy's tip: If procrastination is about **feelings**, the solution isn't a better calendar. It's learning to deal with that uncomfortable feeling for a few minutes – and then just starting. 💜

7 "Let's just get it over with!" listening 10 points



A sister has an important exam next week – and she hasn't started studying. Listen at ⏱ 13:30 and write **one word** in each gap (1–8). Then answer A and B. The breakdown at ⏱ 14:33 can help.



LUCY
Ugh. I really need to start 1 _____ for my exam.



JACK
You said that yesterday. And the day before. When is it again?



LUCY
Next Thursday. I keep 2 _____ it off. Every time I open my notes, I just feel 3 _____. There's so much to learn.



JACK
Okay, so don't try to learn it all tonight. What's the first topic?



LUCY
The first 4 _____, I suppose. But it's really long.

JACK
Then just do ten minutes. Set a 5 _____. If you want to stop after ten minutes, you can stop.





LUCY
Only ten minutes? I can probably 6 _____ that.



JACK
And give me your phone. You can have it back when the timer goes off.



LUCY
Fine. Let's just get it 7 _____ with.



JACK
That's the 8 _____. You've got this.



LUCY
Okay. Thanks. Honestly, I think the worrying is worse than the actual studying.



JACK
It usually is.

A. The exam is next _____.

B. Jack takes her _____ away.

8 Phrases to steal expressions 4 points

Match each phrase from the chat (1–4) to its meaning (a–d). ⏱ 14:33

- ☐ **1.** "I keep putting it off."
- ☐ **2.** "I can probably manage that."
- ☐ **3.** "Let's just get it over with."
- ☐ **4.** "That's the spirit!"

a) Let's do it quickly, so it's finished.
b) Great – I like your positive attitude!
c) I delay it again and again.
d) I can succeed in doing that.

9 Idioms for getting started

idioms · 6 points



Complete each sentence with a word from the box. ⏱️ 15:52

ball · bullet · can · minute · present · round

1. 📞 "Should I call him tomorrow?" "There's no time like the _____!"
2. 🧾 I finally bit the _____ and started my tax form.
3. ⚽ Let's get the _____ rolling with a quick meeting on Monday.
4. 🥫 Stop kicking the _____ down the road – deal with it now!
5. 🧳 He always packs his suitcase at the last _____.
6. 🚲 I haven't got _____ to fixing my bike yet.



Jack's tip: Kick the can down the road 🥫 = instead of putting the can in the bin, you just kick it a little further. The problem doesn't go away – it waits for **future you**! And in American English, people say *get **around** to*.

10 If–then plans

new! plan it · 6 points



Match each **if** (1–6) to a **then** (a–f). With an if–then plan, the decision is already made! ⏱️ 10:21

- ☐ **1.** 🚌 If I'm on the bus to work,
- ☐ **2.** 🍽️ If it's seven o'clock and I've finished dinner,
- ☐ **3.** 📱 If I want to check my phone while I'm working,
- ☐ **4.** 😵 If I feel overwhelmed by a big task,
- ☐ **5.** 📅 If I miss a day,
- ☐ **6.** ☕ If I'm making my morning coffee,

a) then I'll put it in another room.

b) then I'll forgive myself and start again tomorrow.

c) then I'll listen to an English podcast.

d) then I'll learn five new words.

e) then I'll do fifteen minutes of English.

f) then I'll write down the first three steps.



Lucy's tip: Psychologists call these **implementation intentions**. Connect your English to something you **already** do every day – the bus, your coffee, dinner – and you don't have to decide again. Write your own: *If* _____, *then I'll* _____.

11 Say it better

common mistakes · 10 points

These sentences sound unnatural. Write a more natural version (2 points each). ⏱️ 19:25

😐 1. "I am procrastinating my homework." 😊 _____

😐 2. "I did it in the last minute." 😊 _____

😐 3. "I will do it after." 😊 _____

😐 4. "I'm so lazy. I never finish anything." 😊 _____

😐 5. "Tomorrow I will begin, I promise." 😊 _____



Lucy's tip: Procrastinate usually has no object: *"I'm procrastinating."* To say *what* you're delaying, use **put off**: *"I'm putting off my homework."* And **first thing** = early, before anything else: *"I'll start first thing tomorrow."*

✅ Put it off – or put off it?

tick · no points



Tick the right one. Remember: with **it** or **them**, the small word goes at the **end** – and after **keep** and **get round to**, use **-ing**. ⏱️ 15:52

1. Please don't put _____ again! (it)	☐ off it	☐ it off
2. Stop putting _____ – start now! (them)	☐ them off	☐ off them
3. I keep _____ my homework.	☐ to put off	☐ putting off
4. I finally got round to _____ my bike.	☐ fixing	☐ fix
5. I haven't got round _____ it yet.	☐ to	☐ for
6. Why do you always leave it _____ the last minute?	☐ in	☐ until

💭 **Name the feeling!** (no points) Lucy's first tip. When you avoid something, ask: "What am I feeling right now?" – then try the fix. ⏱️ 10:21

🥱 **bored**
Make it a game: set a timer for two minutes.

😰 **scared of doing it badly**
"The first try can be messy. I'll improve it later."

🤷 **don't know where to start**
Write down the first three steps.

😵 **overwhelmed**
Do only the smallest part – one page, one question.

Something I'm avoiding: _____ · I feel: _____ · My fix: _____

🐜 Make the first step tiny!

write · no points



Starting is like pushing a heavy car – the first push is the hardest. Turn each big task into a tiny first step. ⏱️ 10:21

😩 Study English for two hours → 🐜 *Open my book and read one page.*

😩 Clean the whole flat → 🐜 _____

😩 Fix my bike (Jack!) → 🐜 _____

12 Clue word search + secret message

puzzle · 10 points



Step 1: Complete each clue – the first letter and the number of letters are given (1 point each). **Step 2:** Find the 10 words in the grid. They go → ↓ ↘ or ↗ and never cross each other.

1. Lucy avoided her **p**_____ form for three weeks.
2. Once you start, you keep going: **m**_____.
3. The day you must finish by: a **d**_____.
4. Lucy washed the kitchen **c**_____.
5. Grandma bought Lucy's favourite **b**_____.
6. To our brain, future you is like a **s**_____.
7. Do the hard thing: bite the **b**_____.
8. Lucy put her **s**_____ in A–Z order.
9. Just two minutes – set a **t**_____!
10. The easy escape: your **p**_____.

D	M	C	U	R	T	A	I	N	S
E	T	O	S	P	I	C	E	S	S
A	P	H	M	T	I	M	E	R	T
D	I	A	S	E	M	I	T	G	R
L	P	H	S	T	N	E	O	N	A
I	H	L	Y	S	L	T	T	A	N
N	O	K	E	L	P	E	U	L	G
E	N	E	U	V	E	O	N	M	E
M	E	B	I	N	U	T	R	E	R
B	I	S	C	U	I	T	S	T	S

🤫 **Step 3 – the secret message** (no points) Cross out the 10 words. Then write the letters that are left, row by row, from left to right. It's what Lucy thinks now, whenever she wants to put something off!

_____ _____ _____ _____ _____ _____.

13 Lucy's passport story 🛂

listening · 6 points



Listen at ⏱️ 0:05 and ⏱️ 22:00. Put the events in the right order. Write 1–6 in the boxes.

- ☐ 📞 Her grandmother called: "I've bought your favourite biscuits!"
- ☐ 💻 Lucy opened the form and thought, "I'll do this after a cup of tea."
- ☐ ✈️ The form took eleven minutes – the passport came ten days before her flight.
- ☐ 🫙 She put all her spice jars in alphabetical order.
- ☐ ⏱️ She set a two-minute timer and answered the first question.
- ☐ 🧽 She washed the curtains and cleaned behind the fridge.

Think about it 💭 (no points) Why did the two-minute timer work? Use the word **momentum**.

14 Your turn

writing · 8 points

2 points for each good sentence.



A. What I've been putting off 🙈

What is it, and how does it make you feel? *e.g. "I've been putting off a phone call to my bank, because I'm worried it'll take ages."*

B. Dear future me 💌

Write a short note to "future you", like Jack. *e.g. "Dear Friday Maria, I've already done the hard part for you. You're welcome!"*

⏱️ My two-minute week

your 7-day mission

Every day, choose one small thing you've been putting off. Set a timer for two minutes and start. You're allowed to stop – but you probably won't!



Day	The thing I put off	Did I keep going after two minutes?	Done?
1	📧 a message I've avoided		☐
2	📝 a form or a task		☐
3	📞 a phone call		☐
4	📚 two minutes of English		☐
5	🔧 a small repair		☐
6	🗂️ the hardest task first		☐
7	💌 a note to future me		☐

✂️ Cut out and keep in your pocket

🙈 DELAYING
I keep putting it off.
I haven't got round to it.
I'll do it later.

🚀 STARTING
Let's get the ball rolling.
I finally bit the bullet.
Let's get it over with.

💜 BEING KIND
That happened – I'll start again.
That's the spirit!
You've got this.

⏱️ TRICKS
just two minutes
phone in another room
if–then plans

Can you do it now?

I can...	Not yet	Almost	Yes!
explain why procrastination is about feelings, not laziness.	😟	🙂	😄
use put off, get round to and at the last minute correctly.	😟	🙂	😄
make an if–then plan for my English practice.	😟	🙂	😄
use idioms like "bite the bullet" and "get the ball rolling".	😟	🙂	😄



Share it with us! Tell us in the comments what you've been putting off – and whether you **got round to it**. Did you **bite the bullet**? Did you **get the ball rolling**? And have you ever organised something silly to avoid something important? 🧂😅

Answer key

Count your points and write your score on page 1!

0 · Warm-up & predict

Guess: a – only eleven minutes! · Predict: **umbrella** ☂️ isn't in the episode.

1 · Key words · 2 · The big idea

1 c · 2 a · 3 g · 4 e · 5 i · 6 b · 7 h · 8 j · 9 d · 10 f
Big idea: c (2 points)

3 · Know it or hear it?

1 c · 2 a · 3 b · 4 b · 5 c · 6 b · 7 c · 8 a · 9 b · 10 c

4 · True or false?

1 T · 2 F (it's an emotion regulation problem) · 3 F (only for a few minutes) · 4 T · 5 F (they procrastinated less) · 6 T

5 · Three studies · 6 · The circle

5: 1 B · 2 A · 3 C · 4 A · 5 B · 6 C
6: 1 avoid · 2 better · 3 guilty · 4 worse · 5 emotion · 6 time

7 · "Let's just get it over with!"

1 revising · 2 putting · 3 overwhelmed · 4 chapter · 5 timer · 6 manage · 7 over · 8 spirit · A Thursday · B phone

8 · Phrases to steal

1 c · 2 d · 3 a · 4 b

9 · Idioms · 10 · If–then plans

9: 1 present · 2 bullet · 3 ball · 4 can · 5 minute · 6 round
10: 1 c · 2 e · 3 a · 4 f · 5 b · 6 d

11 · Say it better (2 points each)

1 I'm putting off my homework. / I'm procrastinating. · 2 I did it at the last minute. · 3 I'll do it later. / I'll do it in a bit. · 4 I've been putting this off. Let me do a small part now. · 5 I'll start first thing tomorrow.
Put it off? 1 it off · 2 them off · 3 putting off · 4 fixing · 5 to · 6 until

12 · Word search (1 point per word)

1 passport · 2 momentum · 3 deadline · 4 curtains · 5 biscuits · 6 stranger · 7 bullet · 8 spices · 9 timer · 10 phone
Secret: This might only take eleven minutes.



13 · The passport story · 14 · Your turn

1 💻 "after a cup of tea" · 2 🧂 spice jars · 3 🧽 curtains and fridge · 4 📞 Grandma called · 5 ⏱️ two-minute timer · 6 ✈️ eleven minutes
Think about it, e.g.: once she started, she got some momentum and just kept going.
14: your own answers – 2 points per good sentence.

Your score

90–100 🏆 **No time like the present!** · 70–89 🚀 **Great momentum** · 50–69 ⏱️ **Two more minutes** · 0–49 🧂 **Still sorting the spices – try again!**

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